

Dyer can be very funny, and the opening pages of the book, set in London, seem to presage a comic masterpiece. There's the Indian shop-owner "who had so thoroughly adjusted to British life that he looked every bit as pissed off as someone whose ancestors had come over with the Normans", the hairdresser who quotes Sylvia Plath, "Dy(e)ing is an art, like everything else", and the budget airline on which "no expense had not been spared". He writes with an intelligent but sceptical eye about modern art—and until Laura falls for Jeff's non-existent charms, it's possible to believe in the absurdities of the world that Dyer describes in such excoriating detail. Indian readers will probably find the Varanasi part of the book more disappointing;

EXCERPT

On an afternoon in June 2003, when, for a brief moment, it looked as if the invasion of Iraq had not been such a bad idea after all, Jeffrey Atman set out from his flat to take a walk. He had to get out of the flat because now that the initial relief about the big picture had worn off—relief that Saddam had not turned his non-existent WMD on London, that the whole world had not been plunged into a conflagration—the myriad irritations and frustrations of the little picture were back with a vengeance. The morning's work had bored the crap out of him. He was supposed to be writing a twelve-hundred-word so-called 'think piece' (intended to require zero thought on the part of the reader and scarcely more from the writer but still, somehow, beyond him) that had reached such a pitch of tedium that he'd spent half an hour staring at the one-line email to the editor who'd commissioned it:

'I just can't do this shit any more. Yrs J.A.'



he meets some rather dull foreigners, and his longest conversation involving a local is with a goat, with "cute black socks", whom he encounters while in a bhang-induced haze, and who, in best and worst Dyer fashion, may in fact be a boatman. There's a vague attempt at redemption towards the end of the book—but Dyer's always entertaining novel is ultimately more likely to be remembered for its jokes and its sex scenes than for any profound spiritual qualities. ■

A Beautiful Mind

A posthumous meditation on life and solitude that is flawed but dazzling

By Dilip Bobb



WHERE NOTHING
HAPPENS

by PADMANABH
VIJAI PILLAI
Seagull Books
Price: Rs 495
Pages: 176

This is a book that comes with a backstory, tragic yet inspiring. Padmanabh Vijai Pillai died of cancer in 2007 and this posthumous work was written at the urging of close friends who wanted him to leave behind a record of his life and thoughts. He was no celebrity; he retired in 1992 and lived in solitude in Kerala till his death. He was an incredibly erudite man, an unconventional thinker and this book certainly deserved a wider audience. His career mirrored his restless spirit

and mind; educated at Doon school and St. Stephen's, a stint in the Foreign Service, odd jobs in the UK, back to Indian academia, followed by relative oblivion when, divorced, he decides that he is "unemployable" and becomes a retiree, living in relative obscurity.

He writes it in the form of letters to his late mother which adds to its unconventional appeal. It is part memoir, part meditation, an inner journey of self-awareness and self-debate anchored by a spiritual search. It is both dazzling and disappointing. Dazzling, because of his command of the language which turns personal recollections and ruminations on a range of subjects into an intellectual journey that is incredibly intense and rewarding. At its core lies a running metaphysical debate that combines the wisdom of his favourite poets and philosophers and his own experiences and thoughts. It is disappointing because it is a stream of consciousness style that skips from subject to subject without quite doing justice to any. He says he "lacked traction in this world" and that is reflected in this book.

For all that, this is a heroic effort: there is no mention of personal tragedy, the cancer that would take his life, the suffering that he must have endured in solitude. Instead, this is almost a joyous celebration of life. In his critically acclaimed book, *Philosophy of Solitude*, John Cowper Powys wrote that solitude is the necessary social, psychological, and intellectual state of the individual, it helps create a level of discourse that will appeal to the person who desperately needs a philosophy of life, a means of comprehending the world around him. Pillai does exactly that and turns tragedy into triumph. ■